

CORMORANTS, GANNETS, AND RELATIVES

The order Suliformes includes marine species, though some cormorants and anhingas also visit freshwater habitats. The birds in this group have webbing between all four toes.

Frigatebirds cross vast areas of sea but rarely settle on water, taking flying fish or stealing food from other seabirds in the air. Cormorants and anhingas feed on a variety of aquatic species by diving from the surface, while gannets and boobies plunge from a height and are more exclusively fish-eaters.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	SULIFORMES
FAMILIES	4
SPECIES	61

81 cm
32 in

BLUE-FOOTED BOOBY

Sula nebouxii
F: Sulidae

Found on rocky coasts from California to Peru and the Galapagos Islands, this booby flaunts its blue feet as part of its courtship display.

MASKED BOOBY

Sula dactylatra
F: Sulidae

This is the largest of the tropical boobies, with a black and white plumage and long, yellow bill. It most closely resembles the related cold-water gannets.

80–92 cm
31–36 in

yellow tinge to
back of head

white
upperparts

NORTHERN GANNET

Morus bassanus
F: Sulidae

The three similar species of cold-water gannets breed in large colonies on rocky coasts. This one is a native of the North Atlantic.

90–100 cm
3–3¼ ft

snake-like
neck

spear-like
bill

75–95 cm
30–37 in

ANHINGA

Anhinga anhinga
F: Anhingidae

This American species has a long, cormorant-like neck and a straight bill for spearing fish. Anhingas are also called snake birds or darters.

71 cm
28 in

RED-FACED SHAG

Phalacrocorax urile
F: Phalacrocoracidae

A deep-diving seabird found from Japan to the Bering Sea, this species belongs to a group of North Pacific cormorants that are highly adapted to the marine environment.

50–55 cm
20–22 in

LITTLE PIED CORMORANT

Microcarbo melanoleucos
F: Phalacrocoracidae

This is an Australasian member of a group of primitive, short-billed “micro-cormorants” that are largely associated with freshwater or estuarine habitats.

1–1.1 m
3¼–3½ ft

MAGNIFICENT FRIGATEBIRD

Fregata magnificens
F: Fregatidae

Infrequent feeding opportunities and long hours in flight cause frigatebirds, such as this American species, to have a low breeding rate and the longest period of parental care of any bird.

TROPICBIRDS

Large, tern-like seabirds with a long, spike-like tail projection, tropicbirds nest on tropical islands and forage widely at sea.

The three species in this order, the Phaethontiformes, have all four toes joined by webs, like gannets and boobies, but are unable to stand. They locate fish by sight while hovering before plunging from the air. At their breeding colonies, groups of males display in swirling, circular flights, swaying their tail spike to impress watching females.

WHITE-TAILED TROPICBIRD

Phaethon lepturus
F: Phaethontidae

Tropicbirds are streamer-tailed seabirds with feet so feeble that they use their bellies to shuffle on land. This species frequents most tropical coastlines.

76–80 cm
30–32 in

black
“mask”

long, whip-like
tail projection

RED-BILLED TROPICBIRD

Phaethon aethereus
F: Phaethontidae

Found from the E. Pacific to the Atlantic, this typical, hole-nesting tropicbird rears a single, slow-growing chick, an adaptation to scattered ocean food resources.

mostly white with
black wingtips

0.9–1.1 m
3–3½ ft

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	PHAETHONTIFORMES
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	3